Your Obituary is a Dance

By Bernard Cummings

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Writing your own obituary is a lesson in humility. The summary of your existence etched in words that attempt to provide an understanding of who you are,*

ACTRESS: *Writing your own obituary is not morbid, nor does it hasten death, it's simply a way to make peace with your passing and to make things easier on your loved ones.*

ACTOR: *Returning to his Texas hometown, Tommy, a young man dying of AIDS attempts to say goodbye.*

ACTRESS: *Unable to overcome his own and his family's prejudices, his pain goes unresolved until he's reunited with Nella Rae, another outsider who was his childhood friend.*

TOGETHER: *Your Obituary is a Dance by Bernard Cummings*

NELLA: Tommy? *(She crosses to the door)* Tommy, is that you?

TOMMY: Un uh ... oh no, Miss Thang ... you gotta be a little more surprised to see me than that. Start acting like you real happy to be seeing me, woman.

NELLA: Wait a minute, Negro. You know damn well I'm happy to be seeing you after all these years! Now, chill and let me create some atmosphere of suspense here. Now shut up and let me start over. *(She crosses back to the kitchen table. Pause)* Well, knock! *(He plays along)*

NELLA: Tommy?!

TOMMY: Nella Rae! I'm home!

BOTH: Aaahhh!!!!

NELLA: Look what the wind done blowed in! How you doing, baby?

TOMMY: Better now that I'm laying these tired eyes of mine on you.

NELLA: Lord, chile, it's been forever and a couple of days since I done last laid eyes on you. Not to mention heard from your triflin' self. What's the matter? Whatn't no telephones were you was? Postman didn't come by your house or something?

TOMMY: Girl, don't come for me. You know you been on my mind, and definitely with me

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in spirit.

NELLA: Spirit! I ain't known no such thing; so, don't you come for me either.

TOMMY: Look, Diva, don't go there. I already done been read once today, and I ain't trying for another one.

NELLA: You musta' stopped by your Mudear's house first?

TOMMY: Simple as that was, yes. She threw me so much shade that I thought I was deep in the heart of the Amazon Jungle. I could just whip my own black *butt* for stopping by there first.

NELLA: Oooooo, sister-girl read you, huh?

TOMMY: And burned down the library!

NELLA: That "holy-hallelujah-amen corner-kneel at the cross" Mu'dear of yours. Chile, please ... you don't have to tell this girl no more.

TOMMY: Girl, you still a mess. You just as country as a dozen eggs sitting on top of a bale of hay.

NELLA: You damn skippin', And proud of it. So, cock-a-doodle doo!

TOMMY: Where's your man at, Nella? Thought Otis was too jealous to ever leave you alone.

NELLA: Chile, please. Otis is way down by Galveston roughnecking on some oil rig. Wanted me to pack up and go down there with him. Huh! I told him to g' on down there by hisself and to send me the paycheck come paydays and everything would be just fine.

TOMMY: Well, now, I don't mean to be dippin' all up in ya'll's business and whatnot, but how do you know that Otis ain't doing a little "foot shakin" way down there?

NELLA: What I don't know don't concern me. 'Sides, ain't no ring on this finger. Tommy? *(Long pause)* Tell your girl how you doing, baby.

TOMMY: That train is pulling into that station, girlfriend. Truth is, when I consider this

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little ol' life that is mine, I realize that this *stuff* coursing through my veins is par for the course. Nella, I ain't gonna lay up in no hospital bed with tubes and wires coming all out of me. I have no need or desire for that. Understand?

NELLA: Baby, knowing you like I do I truly do understand. That why you home?

TOMMY: Peace to be made. Ghosts to set free. To just see this place where I grew up. To say goodbye, and to finally, finally, let go of it all. Girlfriend, this life has been one tough row to hoe. You know what I mean?

NELLA: Chile, if you told me this was a drama I'd laugh in your face and tell you it was a comedy. Yes, I know what you mean. Being a Black woman in this neck of the woods ain't been no day at the racetrack either.

TOMMY: It's a cryin' shame that I should even think about all these tongues that will be waggin' around here once they find out that ...

NELLA: Oh no no no ... you can stop that noise right there. Chile, please. Self-appointed Righteous Folks love imagining God sitting up somewhere with nothing better to do than to cause folks they don't like misery and grief. Makes 'em feel safe in believing that a God actually exists. Now, baby, look, I can understand you wanting to bury ghosts and everything. But take it from me you don't owe these folks around here a thing. See, most of them talked about me like I had a tail. As you know, I was called every 'fat', 'black', 'nappy headed', 'big nosed', 'African Ju-Ju', name there was when we were growing up ...

TOMMY: ... chile, I remember all that grief ...

NELLA: .. .I know you do. We caught hell, baby. That's why you and I was as tight as we was. But let me say this: Folks had me so wound up with hatred for myself that I became lost. You hear me? Lost. And on top of all that folks still stood righteous, telling me I was gonna' burn in hell. 'Oh yeah,' I said, 'well, your husbands, sons, and brothers gonna' be right down there with me.' Can I get an "amen?"

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TOMMY: 'men!

NELLA: But, baby, when the Truth finally shined its light down on me, and I saw just how SWEET my blackness was-SWEET, do you hear me now? ..

TOMMY: ...I hear you ...

NELLA: Otis finally came into my life all them years ago ... you remember ...

TOMMY: ... sho' do ...

NELLA: I thought that he was crazy as hell. But he LOVED me, baby. And I'm still with *him* cause he showed me 'the darker the night, the brighter the day.' See ... my people, my people ... folks used to make fun of my berry-black blackness when I was growing up. And now you can't seem to turn around without Black folks acting like the last dark African on God's green earth. Folks wearing more Kenre cloth and beads than anybody from Africa wears. All of a sudden it's politically fashionable to be what they tortured me about as a child. And all of it because folks NOW talkin' 'bout some "Afro-American" identity and "reclaiming our roots" and whatnot. Makes me want to scream "Everybody knows we from Africa 'cept us!"

TOMMY: You better PREACH, girl!

NELLA: Whatchu' SAY?

TOMMY: I said PREACH!

NELLA: Whatchu' SAY now?

TOMMY: Preach ON!

NELLA: Witness then like you know how to, baby. 'Cause we may be the outcasts of an outcast race, but we dotted the 'I' and crossed the 'T' in 'identity.'

TOMMY: Oooo, you go, girl. You certainly are philosophical this evening. I stopped by the right place.

NELLA: Speaking of stopping by the right place, what on earth possessed you to stop by you Mu'dear's first? I mean, did you think things might've changed or

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something?

TOMMY: Well, no. 'Cause when she and Papa threw me out of the house all them years back, I was told in no uncertain terms that I had no home there anymore. But, you know, Nella Rae, in some odd way I was hoping that I'd tell Mama that I've got the 'Big A,' that she'd take me into her arms and hold me, tell me she loved me and that everything would be alright. Was I wrong in hoping for that?

NELLA: Un huh ... I see ... well, come here, Jesus. If that ain't about some of the most sentimental crap I done heard in a long time.

TOMMY: Well, it ain't over yet. I'll see her again and next time I'll just speak the Truth ... see what happens ...

NELLA: You KNOW what's gon' happen: Miss sister-girl gon' read you again and send you on your merry way ... with her proslytizing self ... sometimes she makes me just want to slap the taste out of her mouth. Forgive me for saying that, baby.

TOMMY:. *(pause)* Sad to see the house and to know Papa wasn't there anymore. He died about ... what was it ... five years ago, huh?

NELLA: Yeah, that's about right. I even showed up at the funeral hoping you'd surprise us all and be there.

TOMMY: No. That funeral was the last place I wanted to be ... which brings me to a point. *(He opens his duffle bag and takes out a notebook and pen, and sits them on the table.)*

NELLA: What's this for?

TOMMY: We gon' write my obituary together ... *(Overlap dialogue)*

NELLA: •.. aw, hell, Tommy ... un uh ... naw ... we'll have none of this .

TOMMY: now wait a minute, Nella Rae ...

NELLA: .....here we is having a good time, and me up in here on a roll preaching and

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all like I done lost my ever-loving mind ...

TOMMY: . . . Nella Rae, hush and let me ...

NELLA: . . .and here you is wanting to bring us all down with something crazy like this. I ain't gonna' do no such thing. I don't like this-no way and no how ...

TOMMY: I don't like okra. But if I was starving I'd thank God for it and eat it. Now you listen to me: I am alive to do this. ALIVE. This way ... we let go. Let go. *(Pause)* C'mon my fat, black, nappy-headed, and beautiful Waitutsi woman. Me. You. And these words. *(He hands her the notebook. Pause) (She finally takes it.)*

NELLA: *(Pause)* Well, don't be lookin' at me. What you wanna say here? *(Pause. They look at the paper like it's a foreign object.)*

NELLA: Well, we can start by writing that 'He was once a fierce drag queen .. .'

TOMMY: . . . un uh ... don't you come for me. I never did that tired Patti LaBelle, Judy Garland thang. I personified performance art.

NELLA: Chile, please! You couldn't be Judy Garland even if you had Michael Jackson's money and plastic surgeon; and looka' here, I came to Dallas that time you was living there, and I saw that show you did at that cabaret. If that wasn't drag you was doing then I rnust've been blind, cripple and crazy.

TOMMY: Oh, girl, 'bye! I did lot's of confused things in those days 'fore I discovered that that wasn't my cup of tea.

NELLA: Cup?! You had a POT! Chile, who was it you was up there imitating?

TOMMY: .. .lipsynching ...

NELLA: ... whatever ...

TOMMY: . . . Diana Ross!

NELLA: Yea! That was it! And you had the nerve to sing ...

TOMMY: .. .lipsynch .

NELLA: ... whatever some "Sweetest Love Hangover"!

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TOMMY: Wasn't that a big ol' mess!

NELLA: You know, I used to love it when we were kids and you'd put on your Mu'dear's stuff and do me a little show.

TOMMY: You reaching waaaayyy back now.

NELLA: Remember that time she caught us up in ya'll's attic? Who was you imitating?

TOMMY: Donna Summer, girl.

NELLA: That's right! That's right! "Toot toot ... ahhhh, beep beep. Bad girls, talkin' bout those bad girls ... "

TOMMY: And the look on Mama's face when she caught us!

NELLA: Yeah! She looked like she didn't know whether to cry, faint, or holler. All she could do was : "Tommy! agh ugh vvv rrr zzz what you doin? Stop that!" Miss sister-girl lost her mind.

TOMMY: Then she ran your little fat *butt* outta' there ...

NELLA: ... un huh ... accusing me of making you do that. As if she hadn't already noticed you was a big ol' sissy. Chile, please ...

TOMMY: Did I ever tell you what happened after that?

NELLA: Naw, you never did.

TOMMY: Well, honey, she whipped me right out of that page-boy wig and them hot pants. Then she said that she just had to tell Papa so that he could put a stop to my foolishness. Well, Papa came into my room that night, mad as hell, and made Mama put that wig and hot pants on me. And some eyeshadow. That's right, eyeshadow. Chile, bye. Funny, Nella Rae, but the one clear thing I remember in that moment was that Mama was putting some ugly dark purple eye shadow on me, and I was thinking that she had very little taste to be putting that dark purple on my chocolate skin. But she was crying and begging Papa not to make her do it. Now, Papa was never a violent man. Just as sweet as he could be. Didn't like me much, but a very sweet man. But he had this look in this eye like,

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if you don't put it on him and r-a-t now, rat now, I'm gonna slap the taste out of you and this little sissy. Mama wasn't no fool: she put it on me. Then he made me start doing whatever it was I was doing up there in the attic. And, honey, he made that belt talk across my behind. All the while he kept saying that he was beating the deviance out of me. Truth is, I never hated him for that, Nella. I felt sorry for him. *(pause)* But in a lot of ways that whippin' prepared me well for life: if you think I caught hell from Black folks, white folks are truly another story.

NELLA: ... chile, say no more. *(Pause)* So, now what do we put in this obituary?

TOMMY: Look, here it is: I have lived. I have learned. I have lost and won. Done cried. Done lied. And, yes, there were times when I witnessed the Truth. But no regrets' cause now I rest. *(Pause)* The end. *(Pause)* Funny, but me and Papa will be buried side by side. Someday Mama will join us. And finally death will let us be together like life never could.

NELLA: Amen, baby. *(She puts another tape into the jam box. Closes the notebook. Cheryl Lynn's "Got To Be Real" blasts from the speakers.)* Let's party, baby. Your obituary is a dance.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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